

MEMO

MARY 
PELTOLA
for **CONGRESS**

To: Campaign Team of Congresswoman Peltola

From: George Weiler, Campaign Strategist

Re: Final Weeks of Mary Peltola's Campaign for Congress

CONTENT SUMMARY

In the final days of the Peltola campaign, our strategy is as crucial as ever. The following memo outlines essential information from the campaign and three key strategies to deploy as the race comes to a close. The background guide covers two general themes: election-specific information (strength of the field, polling, and fundraising) and information relevant to the campaign (electoral history, demographics, and focal issues).

The field is robust, with three prominent candidates and one third-party candidate. Sarah Palin has taken up the conservative Republican role, allying with Trump. Nick Begich III has a different approach, taking more moderate positions and refraining from the divisive language used by Palin. Finally, Chris Bye, the Libertarian, follows the traditional beliefs of his party and has struggled to maintain importance in the election.

Palin is polling higher than Begich currently, meaning that Mary is more likely to face Palin in the final round than Begich. This means that moderate voters who picked Begich first may be inclined to vote for Mary as their second choice over Palin, whom they may view as too hostile. Bye's votes appear to redistribute evenly across all three candidates.

We are far ahead with fundraising, having raised two million dollars more than our opponents. This lead stems from Mary's success in the special election, which shoved her into the national spotlight.

In general, Alaska is a deep red state. However, this generalization misses essential information, including the prominent blue regions around the coasts and the deep red in the state's center. Additionally, Alaska has a history of electing moderate politicians, including Senator Lisa Murkowski. This may stem from the various populations in Alaska, including a high population of Natives who rely on the water for subsistence. Among the many prominent issues are Trump, abortion, and the climate, which created many ecological disasters (like declining fish and crab populations).

The strategies recommended here reflect the facts. They include using Trump to divide the Republican base, running pro-gun ads in central Alaska, and creating a shocking ad about crab populations to draw more attention to the issues.

STRENGTH of the FIELD

The most crucial factor in winning the upcoming ranked-choice election is the strength of the field and our ability to capitalize on our opponents' weaknesses and strengths. Being a ranked-choice election, voters for every candidate retain importance regardless of their first-choice pick, meaning no candidate is unimportant.

Sarah Palin

Former governor Sarah Palin poses the most evident obstacle to victory in the coming election. In name recognition alone, she has a clear advantage over the other candidates in the field. However, having challenged current president Joe Biden for the vice presidency in 2008 and subsequently falling out of prominence in Alaskan politics, Palin is no longer the Alaskan juggernaut witnessed alongside John McCain.

Palin's campaign is hedging its bets on the ever-growing pool of Trumpian language rather than sound policy to sway voters to come home to the Republican base (the landing page of her website even boasts Trump's endorsement). Her positions are light on policy and heavy on rhetoric. On salmon policy, for example, Palin poses that the solution is to ensure that "illegal fishing — especially by foreigners — is punished" (AlaskaPublicMedia). Compared to Mary's answer to the same question, Palin's answer is missing substance. She calls climate change "a fraud that is peddled by power-hungry politicians" and pledges to end the "radical, destructive agenda" allegedly being pushed by the White House (AlaskaPublicMedia). Every answer uses divisive language meant to energize her base.

Nick Begich III

Hailing from a long-time liberal dynasty in Alaska, businessman Nick Begich has shrugged off his family's Democratic legacy to run as a conservative Republican in the Alaskan House race. However, name recognition isn't everything (especially when running against a former governor), and after placing third in the August, Begich is looking to make a comeback. Begich has taken the moderate path, relying on traditional conservative policy and avoiding hateful language used by Palin. While still sup-

porting similar positions to Palin (unrestricted gun access, allowing the free market to control healthcare), his branding of these issues takes a center-of-the-road approach. For example, he acknowledges Biden's presidency as legitimate while calling for election security, dismisses the power of Congress to impact the climate while seeing the need to reduce pollution, and even plans to address bipartisan issues like data security (AlaskaPublicMedia). Looking at Begich's policy and messaging, it is clear why many of his voters rank Mary as their second choice and not Palin (see Polling).

Chris Bye

Libertarian Chris Bye has the lowest chance of winning this election, polling only in the single digits. Nevertheless, as a ranked-choice system, every voter (and candidate) counts. His campaign has raised only \$1,400 since October, with a total of \$3,800. His fundraising issues are an indicator of his struggling campaign (Bohrer).

Bye's message is consistent, advocating for a third-party candidate who holds the interests of Alaskans above party alignment. It is unclear which party he intends on caucusing with if elected; however, he will likely choose to caucus with Republicans due to many right-leaning policies. Most of his positions are classic libertarian views, from touting Milton Friedman's economic policy to a hands-off approach to gun rights and climate change (AlaskaPublicMedia).

POLLING

Our campaign has consistent polling numbers, often showing leads of up to five points or more over other candidates in the field. However, two types of polls must be analyzed to get the complete picture. First, as a disclaimer, most polling in Alaska is not considered highly reliable by FiveThirtyEight’s pollster rankings. Therefore all polls must be taken not as an accurate recreation of the election but as a straw poll revealing the general direction of the electorate. Also relevant is the recent bias of polls to overestimate the Democratic candidate.

Candidate v. Candidate Polling

Polls pitting Mary against just one of her opponents can show how the election may turn out in the final round of redistribution.

Peltola v. Palin

POLLSTER and DATE RANGE	PALIN	PELTOLA	NET DIFFERENCE
Alaska Survey Research, Oct. 19-22	44%	56%	13 points (Peltola)
Alaska Survey Research, Sept. 25-27	44%	56%	13 points (Peltola)
Dittman Research, Sept. 6-14	42%	58%	15 points (Peltola)
Fabrizio, Lee & Associates, Sept. 6-11	47%	53%	6 points (Peltola)
(Wiederkehr)		AVERAGE DIFF.	11.75 points (Peltola)

Mary holds a significant advantage over Palin, with an average lead of almost 12 points. While these results are almost certainly exaggerated (possibly because they do not take the RCV system into account), they show Mary has considerable support. At the very least, a contest with Palin would be very tight.

Peltola v. Begich

POLLSTER and DATE RANGE	PALIN	PELTOLA	NET DIFFERENCE
Alaska Survey Research, Oct. 19-22	44%	56%	13 points (Peltola)
Dittman Research, Oct. 4-8	48%	52%	3 points (Peltola)
Alaska Survey Research, Sept. 25-27	46%	54%	9 points (Peltola)
(Wiederkehr)		AVERAGE DIFF.	8.3 points (Peltola)

So, despite being the least popular candidate in the special election, Begich has been performing better in polls than Palin. Nevertheless, these polls paint a similar picture: Mary has momentum in Alaska, and any opponent has reason to fear defeat.

Full-Field Polling

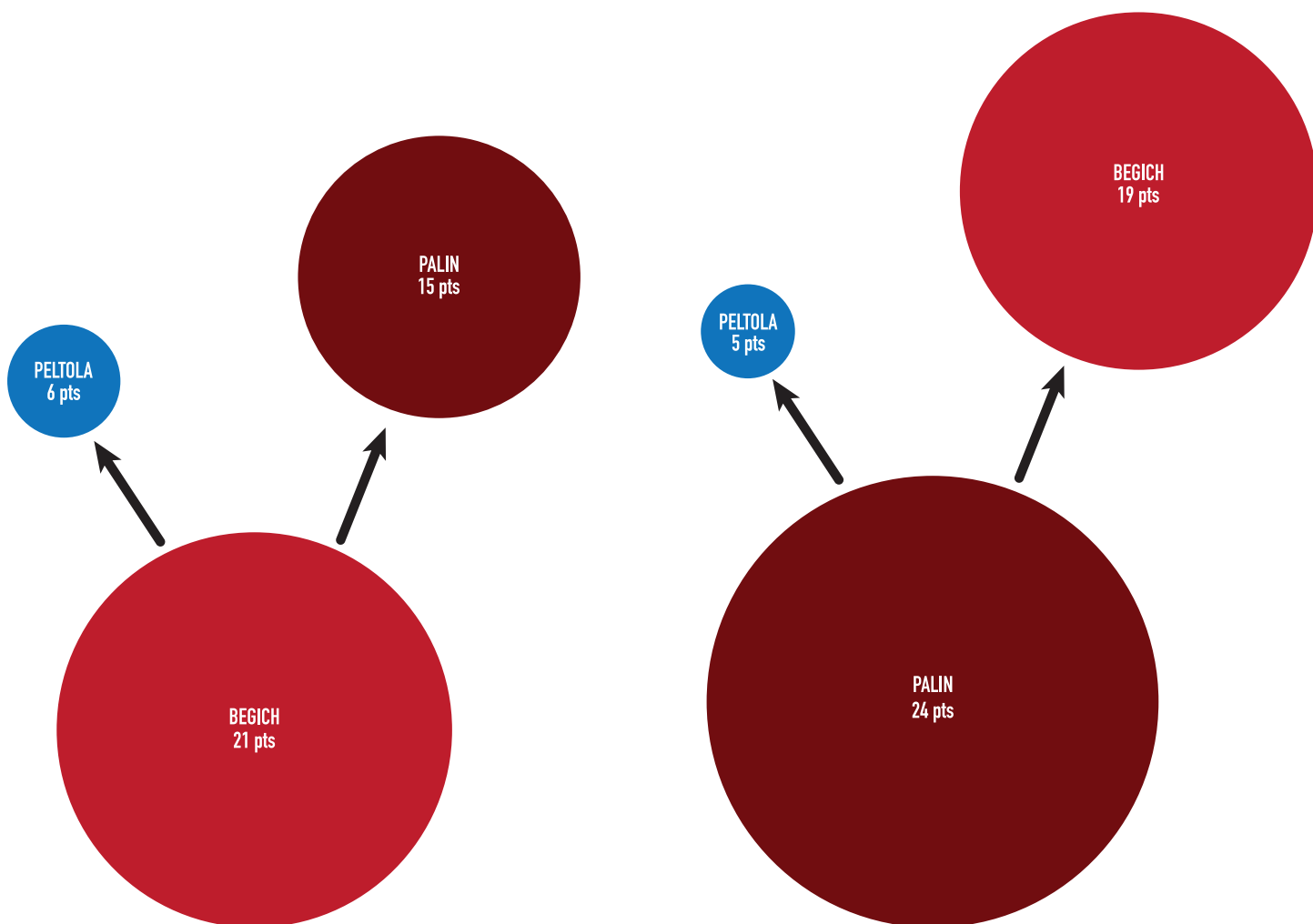
Polling that asks about every candidate in the field in true RCV-style is vital to understanding the early round voting distributions.

Round One Redistribution

This round of voting shows a consistent pattern: Chris Bye gets only a few percentage points, and his votes redistribute somewhat evenly. In all five polls, Mary and Palin received roughly one point from Bye, and Begich gained a point in all but one. Bye's votes are relatively non-partisan and do not favor any particular candidate.

Round Two Redistribution

Round two shows a much less consistent picture. Three polls show Mary and Palin in the final round; two have Mary and Begich continue. In the Mary-Palin races, Mary gained roughly six points from Begich, and Palin gained about fifteen. Similarly, Mary gained approximately five points from Palin in Mary-Begich races, and Begich earned an average of nineteen points.



While these polls are very statistically similar, they allow for some speculation. Begich's stronger performance in candidate v. candidate races may result from the reallocation of votes in round two. Palin voters seemed to rate Begich as their second choice far more often than Begich voters did for Palin. In other words, Palin voters like Begich, Begich voters are split. This split is essential for us because we can utilize the tendency of Begich voters to reject Palin. We get more votes if the contest ends with a Mary-Palin race.

FUNDRAISING

A crucial aspect of any campaign is its fundraising mechanism. Our success as a movement is in the hands of our donors, phone banks, and treasurers, all of whom generate the income our campaign runs on.

Special Election

Our campaign struggled during the special election to outraise our competitors. As of July 27th, only weeks before the election was held, we had raised a total of \$378,887 (FEC). Donations to Palin dwarfed our low fundraising; she outspent us four-to-one (Gedeon). Likewise, Begich's personal loan of \$650,000 (Gedeon) gave him a fundraising advantage.

Current Funds

Despite this monetary setback, we won the special election, granting our movement national recognition and funding. By the end of September, we had raised over \$2.3 million, far more than either candidate in the field (Samuels). This money allows us greater flexibility in our reelection bid and energizes our campaign (it is safe to say that we have "the Big Mo"). Currently, we have enough in our pockets for future ad buys in the closing act of this election.

Sources

We have raised a significant amount of money from PACs, and we still have an impressive grassroots movement, raising \$900,000 in donations of under \$200. Much of that money came from within Alaska as well; roughly \$270,000 was reported with an Alaskan address (Samuels). Similarly, Begich raised money primarily within Alaska, whereas Palin's money comes mostly from outside the state, including from QAnon-linked PACs (Samuels).

Opponent Fundraising

Palin

Palin's fundraising efforts have significantly stalled out after losing the special election this summer. Having only brought in \$230,000 in the last fundraising period, Palin is stuck with a measly \$195,000 on-hand for the remainder of this race (Samuels). Her money issues are compounded by the presence of a second Republican candidate, who is drawing money away from her and subsequently impairing both of their chances of winning the seat.

Begich

Begich has used his vast personal wealth to sustain his campaign since the special election. Infusing his campaign with hundreds of thousands of dollars, he certainly has the funds to continue running a strong campaign. However, his campaign has struggled to raise funds from voters, signaling a struggling campaign. Last month, he reported raising only \$57,000, compared to his \$650,000 personal loan to the campaign (Samuels).

Bye

Chris Bye has raised only \$1,400 as of October, with a total of \$3,800 on hand. His fundraising issues are an indicator of his struggling campaign (Samuels).

ELECTORAL HISTORY of ALASKA

Alaska is a unique state with a solid Republican voting record. While it may seem as though its strong red leaning would provide little insight into Democratic campaign strategy, there are plenty of factors to consider that reveal important information about Alaskan voters.

Special Election

Winning the special election to fill Don Young's congressional seat gave our campaign momentum and national recognition. It also provided a window into our strengths and weaknesses as a campaign and a rare glimpse of how the general may play out. By assessing the special election results, we can analyze where our movement needs to devote resources to come out even stronger in November.

A critical factor in analyzing the results is how the ranked-choice votes redistributed after round one. The tables below show the results after round one, then the redistribution and final results.

Round One Results		
Mary Peltola	39.7%	74,817 votes
Sarah Palin	30.9%	58,339 votes
Nick Begich III	27.8%	52,536 votes
Write-Ins	1.6%	2,974 votes

Round Two Results		
Mary Peltola	51.5%	91,266 votes
Sarah Palin	48.5%	86,026 votes

(NBC News)

As seen here, Mary won by gaining only a mere 16,500 votes after round one, whereas Palin was able to rake in 27,700 votes, likely because straight-ticket voting is so prominent (Brewer and Maisel 48). Furthermore, it shows that Mary does have a strong standing with Begich voters and that there is significant overlap between Begich voters and Peltola supporters.

Recent Presidential Elections

Alaska has consistently voted Republican all but once since it gained its statehood in 1959. However, a clear anti-Trumpian shift has occurred in the past two election cycles. In 2016, a measly 36.6% of voters cast ballots for Hillary Clinton, leaving Trump with a fifteen-point lead typical for Republicans in the deep red state. However, in 2020, Democrats came out to the polls, giving Biden 42.8% of the vote and closing Trump's margin of victory down to 10%, the lowest in any election since 1992 (270toWin). Was this shift blue permanent, or simply a mirage created by a wave of anti-Trump sentiment? Either way, it can be capitalized on by our campaign.

Previous House Races

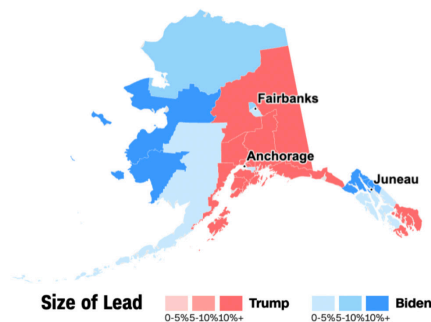
Don Young, a widely respected Republican congressman, held Alaska's at-large district for almost fifty years between 1973 and 2022. After winning reelection twenty-four times, Young established himself as a model for Alaskan politicians who followed him (McFadden). As a result, Alaska Republicans enthusiastically supported him at the polls, consistently winning elections with over 70% of the vote (McFadden).

His willingness to work across the aisle to get things done for Alaskans solidified him as "the Third Alaskan Senator," working with only thirteen other Republicans to pass the trillion-dollar infrastructure bill with President Biden. The legacy Young created while holding this seat is admirable, regardless of political alignment.

Geographic Political Alignment

Despite being deep-red, Alaska has Democratic enclaves that can be seen in the election maps.

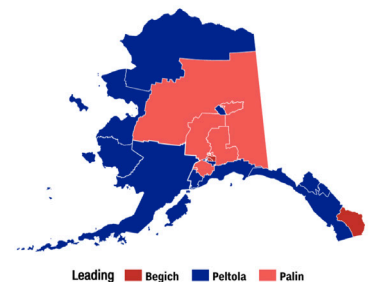
2020 Presidential Election



The map to the left shows the 2020 Presidential election results in Alaska. Trump had a much stronger hold over his red regions than Biden did over his blue ones, as seen by the deeper red color consistent across the center of the map. However, this map does show that inland, Eastern Alaska tends to vote Republican, as opposed to the more Democratic coast.

2022 Special Election

This is seen again with the special election results map from round one, where Mary won primarily coastal areas while her opponents asserted dominance in the Eastern-central region. However, this map may only be partially accurate because vote reallocation could have influenced the outcomes in certain areas.



Combined, these two maps paint an image of Alaska with a clear pattern: coasts are blue, inland is red. Armed with this information, we can assess where there are the most votes to pick up and what issues matter to those voters. Generally, inland Alaska does not have the fishing-based needs of coastal Alaska, and there must be an effort to reshape our message if we want to have presence in central Alaska.

Demographics

Alaska is a majority white state, with over 59% of Alaskans identifying as non-Hispanic whites. While having relatively low Black and Asian populations (3.6% and 6.6%, respectively), Alaska does have the highest percentage of Native Americans in the country, totaling 15.7% (US Census). These communities, like the one Mary hails from, have a unique and complex culture with specific needs. Mary already has strong support from Native Alaskans, stemming from our campaign's focus on fishing and subsistence lifestyle led by many Native communities.

FOCAL ISSUES and NATIONAL MOVEMENTS

This midterm election is plagued with an abundance of local and national issues. These have shaped the election landscape and will continue to influence the minds of voters up until election day.

Trump

Trump is still wildly popular across the country, particularly in conservative enclaves. His endorsement success rate is particularly frightening, with almost four of every five of his candidates winning their elections in 2020 (Kight). Since Mary is currently running against Palin, a Trump-aligned Republican, this could spell trouble on election day. However, Palin's loss in the special election, along with the redistribution patterns in recent polling (see Round Two Redistribution), shows the possibility of rejecting Trump on election day.

Abortion

Social issues often shape the landscape of elections in favor of the party out of power, leading to wave elections (Arenberg). In the past century, social issues, like abortion, have grown to become one of the primary deciders of elections (Brewer and Maisel, 46). While the impact of abortion on Mary's campaign is yet to be seen (and likely will not be seen until election day), it is hopeful that abortion is helping our cause. Recent polling after the Dobbs v. Jackson decision shows that 63% of Alaskans support abortion access in most cases, compared to only 34% against it (PEW Research). Seeing that Mary is the only pro-abortion candidate, these numbers can help us.

Environment

Climate change issues are prevalent in Alaska, a state teeming with wildlife and relies heavily on its natural resources for survival. Unfortunately, the warming climate is causing considerable problems, from melting glaciers to declining wildlife populations. Mary needs to address these issues to have a chance on election day.

Crabs

Recently, the state of Alaska canceled the snow crab season, citing record-low numbers. After a population boom in recent years, 90% of the snow crab population has disappeared, likely for climate-related reasons (Jeong). Crab fishing is a crucial part of the industry and economy of many coastal communities in Alaska. If crab numbers continue to decline, it will not only hurt the fragile ecosystem already disrupted by climate change but also financially ruin the families who depend on crab fishing.

Salmon

Fishing policy has become a focal issue for Mary due to the declining salmon population. Recently, rivers have been mysteriously empty of fish. Where millions of chum salmon usually flood the rivers annually, scientists expect less than 300,000 this year. For Chinook salmon, that number is under 45,000 (Demuth and Ebertz). Salmon is a crucial part of the economy, as well as the lifestyle of indigenous populations. Mary's comprehensive policy will hopefully gain the support of the many fishers and fisheries which rely on the fish population.

STRATEGY

While we hold the advantage as the incumbent and are consistently polling ahead, taking specific, decisive actions at the end of this campaign can help drive home a Democratic victory in what may be a challenging year for the party. Below are three strategy suggestions based on the background information compiled in section two.

Make Trump an Issue

Trump's influence on this campaign is not negligible. Palin has gotten both his endorsement and rhetoric to boost her campaign. Begich, on the other hand, has distanced himself. The polling numbers revealed that Begich's moderate position has made Mary more appealing to many of his supporters, who choose her as their second choice. We can make Trump a more significant issue and emphasize the radical conservatism pushed by Palin. Then, we can drive more Begich voters to write Mary in as their second choice. By capitalizing on the gap between Begich and Palin, we can polarize the two Republican candidates and solidify ourselves as the best second choice.

One way to do this is to create a pledge asking all candidates to accept the election's outcome, regardless of who wins. Palin will refuse (a trademark position for Trump-endorsed candidates). Begich will have two options. If he signs the pledge, his moderate supporters will see the similarities between Begich and Mary, creating more second-choice voters. If he refuses, it may drive away his moderate base, generating more round-one votes for Mary. A sample pledge can be found on the top of the following page.

Advertising in Central Alaska

As seen in the demographics of Alaska, and more specifically, the political alignment of the state, central Alaska is deeper red than the coasts. Coastal Alaska is considerably blue; to win new votes, we must target the red regions to make ourselves an appealing second or third choice. One way to do this is to capitalize on one of Mary's right-leaning policies: gun ownership. Mary owns several firearms, and a well-placed ad will show conservative and libertarian gun owners in central Alaska that Mary will not take away their Second Amendment rights.

A series of advertisements showing Mary using her weapons while using talking points such as "defending the constitution" will show Palin, Begich, and Bye voters that Mary is on their side. Only a few percentage points are needed for Mary to win solidly, and this ad could earn those.

Fish and Crab Stunt

Mary's most prominent issue in this campaign is her fishing policy. A well-timed stunt right before election day that capitalizes on this issue could be exactly what the campaign needs to pull through with a win. Luckily, scientists may have discovered one for us.

Research has shown a gruesome reason for the snow crab population decline: climate-driven cannibalism. Warming water has driven crabs into smaller pockets of cold temperatures, leading to hunger and disease (Baker). To survive, the snow crabs have turned to cannibalism, a shocking and disturbing realization in the scientific community. The ad sample on the bottom of the following page outlines one possible format.

Election Pledge Sample Text

I, (INSERT CANDIDATE NAME), pledge to fully support the winner of the 2022 Alaskan House election, as well as every election result across the country, as legitimate and fairly-conducted elections.

While opinions on candidates differ, and our political views do not always align, democracy is grounded in peaceful transfers of power. Democracy is grounded in faith.

As more candidates across the country are running on platforms of election denial, we in Alaska know that our democracy only functions when we all accept the outcome of elections, win lose or draw. This is an especially important commitment in the wake of our new voting system. I sign this pledge to show my fellow Alaskans that ranked choice voting is fair, that it is good for Alaska, and that it is good for democracy.

God bless the United States, God bless Alaska, and God bless democracy.

Crab Advertisement Sample

Silent footage of snow crabs swarming.

TITLE CARD:

Warming water caused by climate change has forced snow crabs into shrinking pockets of cold.

TITLE CARD:

With short food supply, these crabs have turned to cannibalism.

Close up of crabs cannibalizing

TITLE CARD:

Sarah Palin and Nick Begich believe climate disasters like this are natural processes.

TITLE CARD:

Does this look natural to you?



Playing this ad across the state, especially in coastal areas that rely on fishing, should increase support for Mary and her fishing policy. Additionally, it highlights the clear failures of Begich and Palin's stances on climate change.

WORKS CITED

- 270toWin. "Alaska Presidential Election Voting History." 270toWin.Com, <https://www.facebook.com/270toWin>, <https://www.270towin.com/states/Alaska>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.
- AlaskaPublicMedia. "Alaska's 2022 Election: Compare the Statewide Candidates." Alaska Public Media, <https://www.facebook.com/alaskapublic>, <https://alaskapublic.org/news/alaska-election-candidates/#alaska-2022/position/u-s-representative/>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.
- Arenberg, Richard. "Congressional Campaign History, Part 2." Campaigns and Elections. 3 Oct. 2022.
- Baker, Aryn. "Here's Why Alaskan Snow Crabs Are Disappearing | Time." Time, Time, 19 Oct. 2022, <https://time.com/6222956/alaska-snow-crab-disappearance/>.
- Bohrer, Becky. "Peltola Leads House Challengers in New Fundraising Reports." U.S. News, Associated Press, 27 Oct. 2022, <https://www.usnews.com/news/best-states/alaska/articles/2022-10-17/peltola-leads-house-challengers-in-new-fundraising-reports>.
- Brewer, Mark D., and Maisel, L. Sandy. "The Rise of Cultural Issues." Parties and Elections in America: The Electoral Process, by Mark D. Brewer and Louis Sandy Maisel, Rowman & Littlefield, 2021, p. 46.
- Brewer, Mark D., and Maisel, L. Sandy. Parties and Elections in America: The Electoral Process, by Mark D. Brewer and Louis Sandy Maisel, Rowman & Littlefield, 2021, p. 48.
- CNN. "Alaska Election Results and Maps 2020." CNN - Breaking News, Latest News and Videos, <https://www.cnn.com/election/2020/results/state/alaska>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.
- CNN Politics. "Alaska Democratic & Republican Primary Election Results and Maps 2022." CNN, CNN, 15 Aug. 2022, <https://www.cnn.com/election/2022/results/alaska/primaries>.
- Demuth, Bathsheba, and Olivia Ebertz. "Yukon Salmon Populations Are Falling. The Cultural Damage Is Vast. - The Washington Post." Washington Post, The Washington Post, 15 Sept. 2022, <https://www.washingtonpost.com/outlook/2022/09/15/alaska-salmon-climate-change-indigenous-communities/>.
- FEC. "FEC Disclosure Form 3 for Mary Peltola for Alaska." Campaign Finance Data | FEC, <https://docquery.fec.gov/cgi-bin/forms/C00812388/1621508/>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.
- Gedeon, Joseph. "Democrat Peltola Beats Palin in Alaska Special Election Upset - POLITICO." POLITICO, <https://www.politico.com/news/2022/08/31/democrat-peltola-beats-palin-in-alaska-special-election-upset-00054428>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.
- Jeong, Andrew. "Alaska Cancels Snow Crab Season for First Time after Population Crash - The Washington Post." Washington Post, The Washington Post, 15 Oct. 2022, <https://www.washingtonpost.com/climate-environment/2022/10/15/alaska-snow-crab-season-climate-change/>.

Kight, Stef W. "Charted: Trump's Endorsement Success Rate." Axios, Axios, 20 July 2022, <https://www.axios.com/2022/07/20/trump-endorsement-success-rate>.

McFadden, Robert. "Don Young, Alaska Congressman and Dean of the House, Dies at 88." The New York Times, The New York Times, 18 2022, <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/03/18/obituaries/don-young-obituary-alaska.html>.

NBC News. "Live Alaska House Election Results 2022." NBC News - Breaking News & Top Stories - Latest World, US & Local News | NBC News, <https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/2022-special-elections/alaska-house-results>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.

PEW Research. "Views about Abortion by State - Religion in America: U.S. Religious Data, Demographics and Statistics | Pew Research Center." Pew Research Center's Religion & Public Life Project, <https://www.facebook.com/pewresearch>, <https://www.pewresearch.org/religion/religious-landscape-study/compare/views-about-abortion/by/state/#views-about-abortion>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.

Samuels, Iris. "Peltola Leads Palin and Begich by \$2 Million in Fundraising for Alaska's U.S. House Race." Anchorage Daily News, Anchorage Daily News, 18 Oct. 2022, <https://www.adn.com/politics/2022/10/17/peltola-leads-palin-and-begich-by-2-million-in-fundraising-for-alaskas-us-house-race/>.

US Census. "U.S. Census Bureau QuickFacts: Alaska." Census Bureau QuickFacts, United States Census Bureau, <https://www.census.gov/quickfacts/AK>. Accessed 6 Nov. 2022.

Wiederkehr, Anna, et al. "Alaska : U.S. House : 2022 Polls | FiveThirtyEight." FiveThirtyEight, 28 June 2018, <https://projects.fivethirtyeight.com/polls/house/2022/alaska/>.